

August 2026

Small Area Demographic Estimates

User Notes and Errata

Vintage 20251222



Overview

Small Area Demographic Estimates (SADE) data for 2020-2025 are available now.

The Office of Financial Management (OFM) suggests you use one specific version of SADE data (for example, the 20251222 version) for your analysis. This is because earlier years' numbers might change if new or better information comes in.

The effects of COVID-19 are clear in the 2020-2025 data. Many state and private organizations had fewer people living in their buildings because of pandemic rules. Places where lots of people live together—like college dorms, prisons, jails, nursing homes, and other group homes—were affected by these rules. The SADE numbers show these changes, so you should know that the data varies more from year to year now than it did before the pandemic.

Classification, Data Security, and Access

[Washington State Cybersecurity Program Policy \(Chapter 4\), Data Classification Standard, Number SEC-08-01-S](#) require all state data be given a security level. SADE data has two levels: Category 1 and Category 2.

Category 1 data is published on the OFM website: [Estimates of April 1 population by age, sex, race and Hispanic origin](#), and includes:

- State and County population by single year of age and sex.
- State and County population by minimum Race and Ethnicity categories.
- State, County, Census Tract, Congressional District and School District tabulations by population in 5-year age groups, sex, and minimum Race and Ethnicity categories. All other SADE tabulations are Category 2 data.

This includes data in the MARS 77 format, custom geographic area estimates, detailed race, and ethnicity tabulations, as well as all other custom tabulations.

Category 2: This data is not public. It includes: Data in a special format (MARS 77), custom area estimates, detailed race and ethnicity breakdowns, and other custom data.

To get Level 2 data, you need to sign a SADE End User Agreement. Contact ofmforecasting@ofm.wa.gov or call 360-902-0599 for the form.

How SADE Data is Made

The SADE model uses information from the Census and OFM, including county estimates for race, age, and sex, and data from the Small Area Estimates Program (SAEP). The model uses an iterative proportional fitting method to make sure all numbers match up. It produces estimates for age, sex, race, and ethnicity for small areas and each year.

SADE uses the 2020 Census Modified Age & Race Census (MARC) file. The MARC file sorts the “Some Other Race” category into official race and ethnicity groups. Earlier SADE versions used the 2010 Census Modified Race data for this. For more about MARC, see the [Census Bureau website](#).

County Race Estimates

The 2020 Census and OFM data for 2020-2025 use the Federal Office of Management and Budget (OMB) 1997 standard for reporting race and ethnicity. On March 28, 2024, OMB announced a new standard (Statistical Policy Directive 15, or SPD 15). Federal agencies must use this new standard by September 28, 2029. More information is at <https://spd15revision.gov/> and <https://spd15revision.gov/content/spd15revision/en/news/2025-09-26-bulletin.html>.

County Age and Sex Estimates

The 2020 Census data showed “age-heaping,” which means people often rounded their age to the nearest 5 (like 25, 30, etc.) instead of giving their exact age. This makes some age groups look bigger than they really are. For example, there might be more people listed as 25 than 24 or 26.

OFM fixed this by smoothing the data using a Bayesian random walk method, so the numbers for each age group are more accurate and match OFM data. For more about age-heaping, see the Census Bureau’s [Random Samplings blog](#) on the topic.

Small Area Estimate Program (SAEP) Data

Because the Census Bureau added new privacy rules, OFM adjusted population and housing numbers to make sure they make sense. See the [SAEP User Guide](#) for more about how the data is made and its limits.

OFM also makes corrections to census numbers to improve accuracy. These changes might make OFM data different from the official census numbers, but OFM tries to keep its totals consistent with the April 1 county and city population estimates. For more about these adjustments, see Table 5 in OFM's [Population Trends](#).

2000-2010 Intercensal Estimates

SADE estimates for 2000-2010 have been updated to match 2020 area boundaries. The method and input data have not changed.

2010-2020 Intercensal Estimates

SADE intercensal estimates for 2010-2020 use 2020 area boundaries. The estimates are made using an interpolation method similar to the Census Bureau's. The goal is to make the 2010-based estimates match the 2020-based postcensal estimates in the year 2020. The method creates a time series using both old and new estimates. Differences between the estimates are bigger in later years.

The method assumes that estimates get less accurate as time passes. Therefore, 2010 is most accurate because it's closest to the 2010 Census, and 2020 is least accurate because it's farthest away from the base count. SADE adjusts the estimates with a linear model similar to the Census Bureau's, making smaller changes near 2010 and bigger changes near 2020.

If the method for making postcensal estimates changes, the intercensal estimates will need to be updated. The estimates have been updated to include changes from the vintage 20251222 SADE model.

Changes to the SADE Model

The SADE model used for vintage 20251222 has been updated. The Census Bureau released the 2020 Modified Age and Race Census (MARC) file, and SADE now uses this data for race estimates.

Future Plans

OFM will keep working to improve the SADE model. Plans include adding new race categories from the updated OMB SPD 15 standard, estimating populations in group living situations, and using new data sources.